prepare the ground for the same maneuver. “You shot down one such plane yesterday,” wrote Khrushchev to Castro later that day.[7]

Khrushchev knew that was not the case and admitted it later, in his memoirs. “American planes were constantly flying over the island,” recalled Khrushchev years later. “That drove Castro out of his mind. Castro gave the order to fire, and our soldiers brought down the American reconnaissance U-2 plane with a missile.” Khrushchev the memoirist, as opposed to Khrushchev the politician, was right for the most part. It was Castro’s fear of imminent invasion and his decision to open fire on American airplanes that created a situation in which the Soviet military believed that if they were not yet under attack, it might come any minute, and thus felt justified in using antiaircraft missiles.[8]

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KHRUSHCHEV HAD CLEARLY LOST CONTROL OVER THE SITUATION in Cuba. But not everything was bleak and gloomy for him on that Sunday morning. If his military and his client in Cuba were sources of bad news, there was unexpected good news from the White House. John Kennedy’s letter of the previous night, which had been delivered to Khrushchev, offered hope that the looming nuclear conflict could be avoided.

“1. You would agree to remove these weapons systems from Cuba under appropriate United Nations observation and supervision; and undertake, with suitable safeguards, to halt the further introduction of such weapons systems into Cuba,” was Kennedy’s first condition. “2. We, on our part, would agree—upon the establishment of adequate arrangements through the United Nations to ensure the carrying out and continuation of these commitments—(a) to remove promptly the quarantine measures now in effect and (b) to give assurances against an invasion of Cuba. I am confident that other nations of the Western Hemisphere would be prepared to do likewise.”[9]

True, the letter made no reference to Khrushchev’s latest proposal for the Cuba-Turkey missile swap, but Khrushchev had come up with that idea relatively late in the game, almost as an afterthought, and it certainly was